Lesson 17: Modals in Academic Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 15 Modals.

In this lesson

In Lesson 16 you learned the eight main modals, their form and their common errors. This lesson builds on it: you will learn modal-like expressions (be able to, be supposed to, ought to, had better, would rather), the difference between must not and do not have to, and how to choose a modal by its meaning, its time and its strength. Start with the Pretest in Practice, before you read the rules. Then practice with sentences about customs around the world, and write about customs in your own culture.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Use modal-like expressions (to + base verb) with be or have in the right form.
- Choose a modal by its meaning, its time (past, present or future) and its strength.
- Tell the difference between must not (it is not allowed) and do not have to (it is not necessary).
- Avoid forms that do not exist (mayn't, mightn't) and conversational expressions in formal writing.
- Write a paragraph about a custom with a variety of modals.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
modal-like expression	an expression with to that works like a modal: be able to, be supposed to, have to, have got to, ought to	They are supposed to explain the reasons if they are late.
time reference	the time a verb refers to: past, present or future	had to follow (past), must follow (present and future)
prohibition (n)	things that are not allowed	People must not whistle inside a Mongolian ger.
etiquette (n)	a rule or tradition for proper social behavior	Americans and Europeans have opposite dining etiquettes.
gesture (n)	a movement of hands, arms, or another part of the body to express an idea or emotion	the "OK" gesture with the thumb and index finger
utensil (n)	a dining tool such as a spoon or a fork	Kenyans do not use utensils.
communal (adj)	used or shared by everyone in the group	People in Morocco practice communal eating.
in isolation	separately, apart from each other	Try not to study modals in isolation.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
taboo (n)	an unacceptable word or behavior especially in a group setting	Explain one of the taboos for a wedding ceremony.
improper (adj)	not appropriate, not right	They might think it improper for the children to see their intimacy.
reflect (v)	show, represent	A uniform reflects the school and its reputation.

Rules and explanations

Review from Lesson 16

modal + base form of the main verb = complete verb. In the United States, people should call ahead before visiting someone. (not calls, called, calling, to call)

Three more principles

1. **Contractions:** shouldn't, mustn't and can't are common, but may and might have no contraction. Write may not and might not, never "mayn't" or "mightn't": Small children may not stay alone at home in the United States.
2. **Modal-like expressions** contain the word to, and the base verb follows it: be able to, be supposed to, have to, have got to, ought to. The be or have part changes with the subject and the tense: People have to come on time for an appointment in the United States. They are supposed to explain the reasons if they are late.
3. **Conversation only:** some modals are used mainly in conversation, for example had better and have got to: In Thailand, people had better not touch the head of a statue. In an academic paragraph, should, must or have to are usually the better choice.

Three challenges and one strategy

- The same modal can have different meanings: I can drive a car because I have a driver's license. (permission) / I can drive a car because I know how to drive. (ability)
- The same meaning can have different strengths: a person must have a driver's license (stronger) / has to have a driver's license (less strong).
- Some modals look like the past but mean the present or the future: Some traditions might change quickly. People had better learn the customs of another country when they travel there.
- **Strategy:** learn each modal as a "package" of meaning + time + form, not in isolation. In many countries in the past, young people had to follow the custom of the arranged marriage. (necessity, past: had to + follow) In some countries nowadays, some young people still must follow the custom. (necessity, present and future: must + follow)

Meanings, modals and time

Meaning	Present and future	Past	Example from the book
advice, suggestion	should, ought to (less common), can / could (softer)		Customers should tip the waiters or waitresses for their service.
ability	can, be able to	could, was / were able to	People in ancient India could speak Sanskrit.
permission	can, may; not allowed: cannot, may not	could, could not	In Canada, college students can address / may address their professors by the first name.
necessity, obligation	must, have to	had to	Men have to stand to greet a woman when she enters the room.
no necessity	do not have to		In Iraqi culture, people do not have to kiss each other as a way of greeting.
prohibition	must not		People must not whistle inside a Mongolian ger.
possibility	must, may, might, could (+ not)		This custom may change / might change / could change in the near future.
expectation	be supposed to	was / were supposed to	Last year, Natalia's husband was supposed to buy flowers for her, but he forgot.
preference	would rather (+ than), would rather not		Some young people would rather not get into a marriage than marry someone they do not love.

Must not or do not have to?

- **must not** = it is not allowed: In Thailand and Arabic countries, people must not point their foot or shoe toward others.
- **do not have to** = it is not necessary; you can choose: In Iraqi culture, people do not have to kiss each other as a way of greeting. Handshaking is common.

Practice

Pretest: customs around the world. Do this first, before you read the rules. Is the bold part correct? If yes, choose "correct". If not, choose the other answer.

1. In the United States, people **should to call** ahead before visiting someone. a) correct b) should call
2. In Greece, when children lose a tooth, they **supposed to toss** it onto their roof for good luck. a) are supposed to toss b) correct
3. People **must not show** the "OK" sign with the thumb and index finger in Mexico. The sign is considered vulgar. a) correct b) must not to show

4. In China, a gift receiver **should not opens** the gift in front of the giver. a) correct b) should not open
5. In Malaysia, it is fine to be late for up to sixty minutes, and people **must not apologize** for being late. a) correct b) do not have to apologize
6. In Russia, people **had better not to give** yellow flowers as gifts because yellow flowers mean breakup of a relationship. a) correct b) had better not give
7. People **could not write** their names in red link (red ink) in Korea because a name in red means death. a) cannot write b) correct
8. While paying for a meal in Turkey, people **should not split** the bill because the host will be offended. a) correct b) should not splitting
9. In Japan, people **mayn't kiss** each other as a way of greeting. a) correct b) may not kiss
10. In Thailand and Arabic countries, people **must not point** their foot or shoe toward others. a) correct b) do not have to point

Exercise 1: Dining customs. Underline each mistake in the form of a modal + main verb, and correct it. If the main verb is missing, add it. Example: People can to learn (can learn) about different customs and traditions when they travel abroad.

1. Dinning traditions may the most interesting to most people.
2. In Kenya, guests should to wash their hands both before and after the meal. They cannot sitting with their feet and toes pointing toward any of the other guests or the food. Kenyans do not use utensils. They eat with their right hand. They must not to use their left hand during the whole meal.
3. Americans and Europeans have opposite dinning etiquettes. Americans should holds the knife in their right hand and the fork in their left hand, but the Europeans are suppose to hold the knife in their left hand and the fork in their right hand.
4. People in Morocco practice communal eating. This means that they eat from the communal bowl closest to them. A person must eats using his or her right hand. The left hand mayn't be used to get food. If a bone is taken, the person supposed to suck the marrow from it.

Exercise 5: Possibility, expectation and preference. Write three sentences for each task.

1. Use modals of possibility to write three guesses why seafood is popular on Valentine's Day in the U.S.
2. Use modals of expectation to write three things you are supposed to know when you go to an American family for dinner.
3. Use modals of preference to write three choices of food on New Year's Eve in your home country.

Exercise 7: School uniforms. Read the seven short texts about school uniforms in the lesson material. For each modal + main verb below, give its meaning and its time (past, present or future). The first one is done for you.

1. could be (possibility, present); must wear; may not attend; must be
2. are supposed to be
3. cannot belong; may be; must not exchange

4. may choose; could also wear; would rather have; would rather not spend
5. have to purchase; are able to afford; might increase
6. must wear; do not have to wear
7. Should (schools) require; may disappear; should stay

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the seven questions in Exercise 4 about my home country and the United States. Check my must not and do not have to."
- "I will finish the eight sentences in Exercise 3 (ability and permission) and give two suggestions for each situation in Exercise 2. Correct my modals."
- "Let's discuss three sayings from Exercise 6, such as 'You can't teach an old dog new tricks.' I will explain each one and translate a similar saying from my language."
- "Check my list of modals in the essay 'How to Spend the Summer?' (Exercise 8), with the meaning and time of each."
- "Here are my two paragraphs: [paste]. List every modal, check its meaning and form, and replace had better or have got to with a more formal choice."

Read aloud

- In the United States, people should call ahead before visiting someone.
- In Malaysia, people do not have to apologize for being late.
- People must not whistle inside a Mongolian ger.
- Customers ought to tip the waiters or waitresses for their service. (ought to = /ˈɔːtə/)
- On that day, women are not supposed to do much housework. (supposed to = /səˈpoʊstə/)
- Parents would rather pick someone as their future son-in-law or daughter-in-law than let their child decide.

Writing task

Exercise 9: choose two of these topics and write a paragraph of 8-12 sentences for each.

1. one of the holiday dining traditions in your native country
2. some customs about naming a baby in your native country
3. one of the taboos for a wedding ceremony in your native country
4. Some people say that elderly parents should live with their adult children. Do you agree or disagree? Why?
5. In America, it is common to "go Dutch" (split the food bill in the restaurant). Is this practice common in your native culture? Who usually pays for the meals?
6. the joys and challenges of living in two cultures, and your biggest culture shock (if you have not lived abroad, write about a new city or school)

Each paragraph needs a topic sentence, supporting details and a concluding sentence. Use at least five different modals or modal-like expressions with at least three meanings (for example necessity, prohibition, expectation, preference, possibility).

Checklist:

- Is every modal followed by a base verb (must eat, not must eats)?
- Do your modal-like expressions have the right form of be or have (are supposed to, has to, was able to)?
- Did you write may not and might not (not mayn't, mightn't)?
- Did you use must not for things that are not allowed and do not have to for things that are not necessary?
- Is the time right (had to and could for the past)?
- Did you replace had better and have got to with should, must or have to?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Pretest. (book) 1. b) should call 2. a) are supposed to toss 3. a) correct 4. b) should not open 5. b) do not have to apologize (being late is fine, so an apology is not necessary) 6. b) had better not give 7. a) cannot write (a custom today, so present) 8. a) correct 9. b) may not kiss 10. a) correct

Exercise 1.

1. may the most interesting: may be the most interesting (the main verb be is missing)
2. should to wash: should wash; cannot sitting: cannot sit; must not to use: must not use
3. should holds: should hold; are suppose to hold: are supposed to hold
4. must eats: must eat; mayn't be used: may not be used; supposed to suck: is supposed to suck

(Dinning in items 1 and 3 is a spelling mistake in the book for dining. It is not part of the exercise.)

Exercise 5. (example answer)

1. Seafood may be popular because it seems special and romantic. Restaurants might offer special seafood dinners on that day. Some people could think that seafood is a luxury.
2. You are supposed to arrive on time. You are supposed to bring a small gift, such as flowers or a dessert. You are supposed to thank the hosts before you leave.
3. On New Year's Eve, my family would rather eat grilled fish than fast food. My father would rather have rice with lamb. My sister would rather not eat sweets late at night.

Exercise 7. (Some modals can have two readings; both are given.)

1. must wear: necessity, present; may not attend: permission (not allowed), present; must be: possibility (a strong guess), present
2. are supposed to be: expectation, present
3. cannot belong: possibility (here: it is not possible), present; may be: possibility, present; must not exchange: prohibition, present
4. may choose: permission, present; could also wear: possibility or permission (another choice), present; would rather have: preference, present; would rather not spend: preference, present
5. have to purchase: necessity, present; are able to afford: ability, present; might increase: possibility, present or future
6. must wear: necessity, present; do not have to wear: no necessity, present
7. should (schools) require: advice, present; may disappear: possibility, future; should stay: expectation, future

My notes